



EVEN IMPRISONMENT HAS NOT BEEN ABLE TO IMPACT GEORGE'S VICTORY MARCH IN THE PAST



TOTAL ELECTORATE: 13,21,478

George has represented Muzaffarpur in the Lok Sabha for five terms in 1977, 1980, 1989, 1991 and 2004.

Areas of Concern

Population: 37.46 lakh,

Literacy Rate: 48.15 per cent

Per Capita Income: Rs 4,058

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GEORGE FERNANDES

travels beyond the otherwise rigid caste boundaries in the state. "George Saheb is the best man around. Had he been physically okay, we'd have voted for him," says Deonandan Choudhary, 69, of Rajela village in Muzaffarpur. There are others, however, who will still go for George.

He does not express his hurt, as the JD(U)—the party that he founded—picked turncoat Jai Narain Nishad to replace him as its candidate from Muzaffarpur. But ask him about Nitish Kumar and his development, and his eyes light up. "I'll take him to the market, anywhere in Bihar and ask him to show the development. You ask him for me," he says, his voice unflustered, detached yet feeble.

Once a champion of socialist politics

who straddled the Indian political space for decades, George today walks in laboured baby steps to his vehicle. It's really ironical for the man, who once as the president of the All India Railwaymen's Federation had led one of the most impressive railway strikes in 1974, where over 1.5 million workers had participated.

A section of the Muzaffarpur electorate sees George, who will turn 79 in two months, as just a pale, struggling and incoherent shadow of his fiery self. "No point wasting our votes on him. He should retire peacefully," said Udai Kumar of Orai, Muzaffarpur. But there are many who believe that ignoring George would be tantamount to insulting a family elder.

Meanwhile, by turning George into

a rallying point, many detractors of Nitish Kumar like Jagannath Mishra, Shambhu Sharan Srivastava, Upendra Kushwaha and P.K. Sinha have found a method in him to oppose the Bihar chief minister. And George's rebellion is proving to be a trouble zone for Nitish and Sharad. George's fight is definitely beyond symbolism as his presence may still cut across caste affiliations, something that kept him in the electoral contest so far.

Despite his apparent physical handicap that may wean away some of his supporters on D-Day, George is yet to be written off perhaps because his opponent Nishad fails to inspire much confidence. In the past, Nishad had been hopping parties like college-goers do on a Saturday night. No wonder, Nitish visited Muzaffarpur thrice to campaign for his party candidate.

Ironically, there was a time when George had projected Nitish Kumar to oppose the hegemony of Lalu Prasad in Bihar. He was one of the founders of the Samata Party which he and Nitish formed after severing ties with Lalu Prasad. Later, he was ousted from the post of JD(U) president when Nitish sided with Sharad Yadav, replacing the veteran patriarch.

George may not be able to withstand the rough and tumble of electoral politics. His opponents argue that it won't help Muzaffarpur to have a symbolic representation in Parliament. But are Nitish and Sharad above board while denying George a ticket? There are two views, one of which suggests that Sharad's sending a letter to George to offer him a Rajya Sabha ticket indicates that JD(U) president was offering a cold shoulder to the party veteran.

Indeed, both Sharad and Nitish could have visited George instead of sending him a letter to say he was no longer required in the Lok Sabha. In Muzaffarpur, George Fernandes, however, appears unconcerned. His hands folded, George eyes people, his face totally intent as his convoy rolls. Suddenly a faint smile flickers on his face as a gust of hot wind eddies across. He makes a fist and punches the air with quivering lips. The Xylo races on and melts into the horizon. ■